

WHY THIS POLAVARAM D?
The Godavari in spate at the Polavaram dam project site in Andhra Pradesh

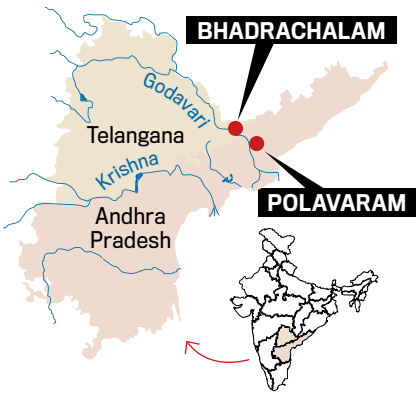
ANDHRA PRADESH/ TELANGANA

SLUICE-GATES OF SORROW

By Amarnath K. Menon

As the Southwest monsoon lashed through most of July, flash floods caused by the waters of the Godavari river hit the temple town of Bhadrachalam and surrounding areas in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. It reignited an old row about water management between the states. At its centre is the under-construction Polavaram dam project 73 km downstream of Bhadrachalam on the Godavari in Andhra. Telangana alleges that an unauthorised raising of the dam is the root cause of widespread flooding in upstream areas and demands an immediate reduction. The on-site cofferdam—a watertight enclosure under water to help construction, built to a height of 41.5 metres—has captured large volumes of water, leading to its backwaters submerging upstream habitations up to Bhadrachalam. On July 30, Telangana wrote to the Polavaram Project Authority, asking it to get the impact of the project's backwaters on Bhadrachalam and surrounding areas, including the heavy water plant of the Department of Atomic Energy at Manuguru, studied by an independent agency. "The backwater impact on Bhadrachalam will be a common phenomenon once the Polavaram project is completed and water is stored at full reservoir level," the letter cautioned.

The project on the Godavari near Ramayyapeta village in Polavaram mandal aims to irrigate 436,825 ha, generate 960 MW of hydropower, provide drinking water to 2.85 million people and divert 80 tmc water to the Krishna river basin. However, it comes at a cost—it's estimated that over 100,000 families will be displaced from 289 submerged villages—277 in Andhra, eight in Chhattisgarh and four in Odisha. Both neighbouring states have raised objections.



Puvvada Ajay Kumar, Telangana transport minister, demands that five villages in Bhadrachalam mandal that went to Andhra when the state was divided in 2014 to facilitate the construction of the Polavaram project—along with other villages across several mandals—should also be returned. On July 24, that demand led residents of those flood-ravaged villages—Kannaigudem, Pichukalapadu, Yetapaka, Gundala and Purushothapatnam—to gather at Rajupeta along the Telangana-Andhra Pradesh border for a *rasta roko* protest.

With the transfer of villages, says Kumar, Telangana can take substantive measures like building embankments to prevent floods. "Villagers came to camps in Bhadrachalam to take shelter as the AP government did not come to their rescue," he says. The ruling Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) wants the Centre's intervention to both reduce the dam's height and transfer the villages.